Q+A

LITERARY QUARTET

Upamanyu Chatterjee is out with *The Hush of the Uncaring Sea*, a collection of four novellas

Q.
The titular novella 'The Hush of the Uncaring Sea' is about a Bengali Everyman who, after a series of misfortunes, gets marooned at sea. Tell us about the origins of this story.

My brother Beetashok has been a 'shippie'–30-plus years as a sea captain. Since retiring, he has been writing nautical stories, which I enjoy. The protagonist Abani's story came out of two paragraphs in one of his stories.

Q.
'The Revenge of the Non-Vegetarian' was written in 2018, but feels eerily topical...

It does feel that way, yes. But I wasn't trying to make a political point when I had written the story. Conflicts over food habits, veg-nonveg is something as old as this land itself and I wanted to use that framework to tell a story about my character Agastya Sen's father, Madhusudan Sen, who's also an IAS officer.

Q.
How difficult is it to write about racism set in the past–as is the case with the final novella, 'The Hapless Prince'–and not have modern attitudes about it seep in?

'The Hapless Prince' was partially inspired by the Billy Bunter schoolboy stories–they had an Indian character and plenty of racist stuff, but we all read them. I wanted to write a kind of Billy Bunter story, only with a proper, actual Indian character, not a stereotype.

Q.
Any writers who spring to mind when you think of the novella form?

Nobody in particular, I'd say, although Henry James and even Leo Tolstoy wrote some wonderful novellas in their time. For me, it's the plot, the story itself that dictates the likely length of a work. While I'm writing it, the correct rhythm, the correct word length suggests itself.

–with Aditya Mani Jha

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